Sales Training Debrief — Session 19

Reheat the Pie. Sell the Appointment Twice.

Sales training led by Corie Dawson, Director · Friday 29 May 2026 · Marketing Sweet

1. Bookings made by someone else go cold — fast

The session opened with a structural problem in how the sales team treats inherited bookings. When the lead-gen team books a meeting and hands it over, the rep on the receiving end tends to assume the buyer is already sold on the appointment. That assumption is the source of most no-shows and same-day cancellations. From the buyer's side, the meeting was booked days ago, the energy of the first conversation is gone, and the meeting feels like just another item on a busy calendar.

> *"You're banking on the fact that the buyer is going to enjoy that cold pie. They won't. You need to reheat it."*

The key mindset shift:

- The lead-gen team passes the buyer to the rep — they don't pass the buyer's commitment.
- The longer the gap between booking and meeting, the more reheating is required.
- If the rep treats the booking as warm, the buyer treats the meeting as optional.
- Every cancelled or no-show meeting started life as a warm booking that wasn't reheated.

2. The cold-pie principle

The metaphor at the heart of the session. A pie made fresh is delicious. The same pie, left on the counter for three days, is jelly. The pie hasn't changed — but its appeal has collapsed. The same logic applies to inherited bookings. The deal is exactly the same as when the lead-gen rep booked it, but the buyer's emotional engagement has dropped sharply over time. The rep's first job is to put the pie back in the microwave.

FRESH PIE · RIGHT AFTER BOOKING	COLD PIE · THREE DAYS LATER
Buyer remembers the lead-gen conversation	Buyer barely remembers booking it
Buyer is curious about the agency	Buyer has shifted attention to other priorities
Buyer expects the meeting to happen	Buyer is looking for a reason to skip it
Energy is high, defences are low	Energy is gone, defences are up
A short pitch lands easily	Even a great pitch hits a flat audience

> *"You're not rocking up to a warm appointment. You're rocking up to a cold pie, and you've got to reheat it before you serve it."*

3. The day-before confirmation call

The reheating mechanic. Not the day-of-call, not the moment-after-booking call — the day-before call is the right window. Early enough that the buyer can fit the prep into their day, late enough that the meeting feels imminent. The call has a specific structure designed to do two things at once: confirm the meeting, and reheat the engagement that's gone cold.

The four-part script:

1. Open with high energy. "Hi Jeanette, it's Philippa here from Marketing Sweet — really excited to catch up with you tomorrow."
2. Reference the original conversation. "I had a look at your website after Sean's chat with you on Wednesday — I can see exactly what he was talking about."
3. Ask for prep. "For tomorrow's meeting, could you send me three or four competitors you'd really like to win work from? It'll help me prepare properly."
4. Confirm timing and tone. "We've only got 5–10 minutes booked. I just wanted to make sure you knew what to expect — does that all sound good?"

THE OUTCOME The pie is back in the microwave. The buyer remembers why they booked, they have a small homework task that creates investment, and the next-day meeting is no longer a calendar item — it's an event.

4. Time as currency — the 5–10 minute frame

A subtle but powerful move. The confirmation call (and the meeting itself) is always framed as 5–10 minutes. This is not literal — most meetings run longer. But the frame defuses the buyer's biggest objection ("I don't have time") and creates asymmetric risk. If the meeting genuinely takes 5 minutes, the buyer is delighted. If it runs to 45 minutes, the buyer doesn't get angry — because the rep didn't trap them. They chose to keep going.

> *"Time is a currency. Saying 5–10 minutes has no downside. If it runs longer, the buyer extended it themselves. If it runs short, you've impressed them."*

The 5–10 minute frame in action:

- Use it in the confirmation call. "We've only got 5–10 minutes — I just want to know if you're still up for it."
- Use it in the meeting opener. "Look, I know we've only got 5–10 — I'll keep this tight."
- Don't deliver on the literal 5 minutes. Once the buyer is engaged, the time becomes their decision.
- Never force the buyer to commit to a longer window upfront. Asymmetric risk is the whole game.

5. Sell the appointment twice

The mindset shift the session was driving home. The lead-gen rep sells the appointment once — when they book it. The receiving rep needs to sell it a second time — at the confirmation call. Skip that second sell, and the buyer's belief in the value of the meeting decays. Run the second sell well, and the buyer arrives at the meeting with renewed conviction that this was worth booking.

What the second sell sounds like:

- "I've had a look at your website after Sean spoke with you, and I think there's a couple of really specific things we can fix quickly."
- "Just out of interest, I also wanted to flag — we've got some great news on a sign-up offer running this month. I'll explain when we catch up."
- "It's only going to take 5–10 minutes. By the end of it, you'll have a clear sense of whether what we do is right for you."
- "I'm really looking forward to meeting you."

6. The full-calendar trap

A pattern that destroys conversion. A rep with a calendar full of bookings looks at the screen and feels successful. The mindset shifts from "I need to win every one of these" to "some of these will fall out — that's normal." The instant the rep accepts attrition as normal, attrition rises to match expectations. The week that started with twelve bookings ends with two deals.

> *"You see a full calendar and you think 'thank god, the booking work is done.' That's a poor person's mentality. A full calendar isn't done — it's the next job."*

The reframe:

5. Treat every booking as if it's your last booking. Prepare for it like a first meeting.
6. Aim for 100% conversion, not industry-average. The internal target shapes the energy.
7. A full calendar is a leadership challenge, not a leadership reward. The rep's job has just begun, not finished.
8. When the calendar is full, that's exactly when the confirmation calls matter most — more bookings = more reheating.

7. Big energy on the call — soft confidence in the room

A subtle distinction. Big energy doesn't mean loud, performative, or over-caffeinated. It means showing up as someone who clearly cares about the outcome and is excited to be in the conversation. Soft confidence means not bulldozing the buyer — the rep believes in the recommendation but presents it in a way that leaves the buyer room to choose.

> *"Big energy isn't 'rah rah rah.' It's 'you're in good hands.' That's what the buyer is buying — confidence without pressure."*

How it lands tactically:

- Open with genuine enthusiasm — "really excited to catch up" — not performative cheer.
- Recommend with conviction but soft framing — "I think this is going to work for you, hopefully you agree."
- Slow down when the moment matters. Confidence is not measured in speed.
- Match the buyer's natural register. Don't out-energy them; meet them where they are.

8. The "next step" close

A specific closing line that surfaced in the session. Said with the right inflection — slightly down at the end, no question mark — it removes the buyer's exit. Said as a question, it gives the buyer permission to delay. The difference is one of delivery, not vocabulary.

> *"Sounds like you're ready to go the next step."*

The mechanics:

- Said as a statement, the buyer either agrees (yes) or has to actively buy time ("what's the next step?" — which itself signals interest).
- Said as a question ("are you ready to go the next step?"), the buyer can default to "let me think" — and the close evaporates.
- The intonation is the whole technique. Practice it out loud until it lands flat.
- After the line lands, stay silent. The buyer breaks the silence — and the next words they say reveal whether they're in or out.

9. The apology close — when the buyer says "I don't want to be pressured"

The buyer pushes back. "I don't want to be pressured." The natural rep response is to defend — "I'm not pressuring you." That defence usually makes it worse. The session's technique is the inverse: apologise immediately, take ownership, soften, and shift the dynamic so the buyer ends up being the one to recover the relationship.

> *"I'm really sorry, mr. Smith. I'm just extremely enthusiastic to win your business. I didn't mean to pressure you — that's my fault. I'll send the proposal through, and if you want to go ahead, fill it out. If not, no problems at all."*

Why this works:

- Apologising removes the buyer's leverage. They can't push back against someone who's already stepped back.
- Owning it ("that's my fault") signals professionalism — most reps argue, which validates the buyer's complaint.
- The recovery line offers two paths: take the deal, or walk. The buyer almost always softens — "no, no, you weren't pressuring me" — and the deal re-engages.
- If they don't soften, the rep finds out fast that the deal was never going to close. Either answer is useful.

10. Action items this week

9. On every booking inherited from lead-gen this week, run the day-before confirmation call. Use the four-part script.
10. Frame every meeting as 5–10 minutes — on the confirmation call and in the meeting opener.
11. Notice your reaction to a full calendar. If you feel "job done," reset — the job has just begun.

12. Try the "next step" close on one pitch this week. Practise the flat intonation out loud first.
13. If a buyer says "don't pressure me," don't defend — apologise, offer the two paths, watch them recover.
14. Bring big energy on confirmation calls. Match it with soft confidence in the meeting itself.

THE ONE-LINER Bookings go cold. Reheat the pie. Sell the appointment twice. Confidence without pressure. The next step is the close.